

FREE DOWNLOAD

How to Get Ready *for Your Engagement* Session.

Everything you need to know before you arrive.

What to wear — as individuals and as a couple.

How to coordinate outfits without matching.

Hair, makeup & grooming for both of you.

Austin-specific timing and location tips.

How to prepare mentally and logistically.

What to expect from start to finish.

FE

WELCOME

Your Engagement Session Is a Gift. To Each Other, and to your future selves.

"The best sessions happen when both of you feel comfortable, prepared, and completely yourselves."

Your engagement session is one of the most personal portrait experiences you'll have — just the two of you, no wedding-day pressure, no audience. It's a chance to be photographed exactly as you are right now.

The images will live on your save-the-dates, your wedding website, framed in your home, and in your family's hands for decades. How you prepare directly affects how you'll feel on camera — and that shows in every frame.

This guide covers everything: what to wear, how to coordinate as a couple, hair and makeup, grooming, Austin-specific timing, and what to expect from start to finish.

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ENGAGEMENT SESSIONS — AUSTIN, TEXAS

Ready to book? Reach out at nydamphoto.com

We respond the same day on weekdays.

01

What to Wear — Her.

Your outfits set the entire mood of the session. Choose looks that feel genuinely like you — not what you think engagement photos ‘should’ look like. Comfort reads on camera more than any trend.

BUILD YOUR TWO LOOKS

- + **The elevated look.**
A flowy midi or maxi dress, a tailored two-piece set, a silk blouse with wide-leg trousers. Something that feels dressy but unmistakably you. This is the look that gets framed. Choose something you can move in.
- + **The real-you look.**
Jeans and a great top, your favorite jacket, something you actually reach for. This is often where the most genuine images happen — because you’re most comfortable, and that shows.
- + **Start with your hero piece.**
Every look has one starting point — the dress, the jeans, the statement top. Build everything else around it. Then add a completer piece: a jacket, a wrap, a belt. This gives us variety mid-session.
- + **Bring a third option.**
A lightweight layer, a hat, a pair of earrings that changes the feel of an outfit. These small additions create variety without a full outfit change and give us more to work with.

WHAT PHOTOGRAPHS BEAUTIFULLY

- + **Soft, muted tones over bright colors.**
Cream, dusty blue, sage, terracotta, warm camel, blush, soft ivory. These tones let your face and your connection be the focus. Neon and stark white compete with both of you.
- + **Texture and movement.**
Chiffon, linen, flowy cotton, knit, lace. Fabrics that move create beautiful, alive images — especially outdoors in any breeze. Stiff fabrics limit your movement and create stiff-looking poses.
- + **Fitted silhouettes, not oversized.**
Well-fitted clothes photograph clean and polished. Oversized pieces can look shapeless on camera. Fitted enough that the clothes complement rather than hide your shape.
- + **Shoes that are actually walkable.**
We move constantly — through fields, parks, sidewalks, and uneven Austin terrain. Stilettos sink into grass. Chunky heels or wedges give you elevation with real stability.
- + **Avoid large logos and busy prints.**
They pull attention away from your face and your partner immediately. If you love a pattern, keep it subtle — small florals, fine stripes, tone-on-tone texture.

WEAR THIS

- + Soft neutrals and earth tones
- + Texture: linen, chiffon, knit, lace
- + Fitted silhouettes that allow movement
- + Coordinated with your partner, not matching

AVOID THIS

- Neon or overly bright colors
- Large logos and busy prints
- Brand new shoes not yet broken in
- Anything you’ll constantly adjust

02

What to Wear — Him.

Most guides focus entirely on her. This one doesn't. What he wears matters just as much — and the right choices make the entire session feel more intentional and cohesive.

THE TWO LOOKS

+ The elevated look.

A well-fitted button-down (tucked or untucked), chinos or dark denim, leather shoes or clean white sneakers. Not a suit unless that's genuinely you. Think polished without costumed.

+ The casual, real look.

Dark jeans or chinos with a fitted tee or soft shirt, a jacket or flannel you can remove. Something you actually wear. Casual doesn't mean sloppy — fitted basics always photograph better than oversized.

+ Fitted beats baggy — every time.

Well-fitted clothes photograph clean and confident. Loose or baggy fits look sloppy on camera regardless of how relaxed they feel in real life. You don't need to go tight — just fitted.

+ Grooming matters more on camera.

Plan your haircut for 3-5 days before — not the morning of. Shave or trim the night before to avoid razor redness. Clean and pressed. The camera catches everything.

WHAT WORKS ON CAMERA

+ Solid colors and subtle textures.

Solid neutrals, fine patterns, subtle texture — linen, chino, denim, Oxford cloth. These keep the focus on your face and your partner. Large logos and bold graphics compete with both of you.

+ Match the formality level — not the outfit.

If she's wearing a flowy maxi dress, a button-down and chinos is the right level. If she's in jeans and a great top, a tee and jacket works. You should feel like a couple, not like two strangers.

+ Dark denim photographs beautifully.

Dark wash jeans are one of the most versatile choices — they work for both elevated and casual looks. They photograph cleanly without distracting from your face.

+ Layers give you options.

An open jacket, a flannel you can tie around your waist, a shirt you can unbutton — layers let us create variety mid-session without a full outfit change.

+ Skin care matters more than you think.

Moisturize daily starting a few days before. On session day: SPF-free or chemical SPF formulas to avoid flashback. Mattifying powder reduces shine without looking made up. Available at any drugstore.

THE SHORT VERSION FOR HIM

Haircut 5 days before. Shave the night before. Wear fitted. Choose solid colors. Send us photos of your outfits if you're unsure.

03

Coordinating as a Couple.

Coordinated looks intentional. Matching looks like a costume. The goal is to feel like you belong in the same frame — not like you got dressed together in the same outfit.

HOW TO COORDINATE WELL

- + **Build from a shared color palette.**
Choose 2-3 colors that work together and let each of you interpret them individually. Dusty blue and warm cream. Sage and terracotta. Warm camel and deep navy. Coordinated, not identical.
- + **Vary the formality within the same level.**
If one look is elevated, both looks should be elevated. If one look is casual, both should be casual. The looks don't need to match — they need to feel like they belong together.
- + **Avoid head-to-toe matching.**
Wearing the exact same color in the same tone creates a visual blob on camera. Let one of you anchor with a neutral while the other brings the color.
- + **Photograph your outfits together before the session.**
Lay both full looks out side by side and take a photo. If they work together on the floor, they'll work together on camera. Send us the photo if you want honest feedback.
- + **Consider the location.**
Urban sessions: structured, editorial, bolder tones work well. Natural outdoor sessions: flowy, earthy tones, texture. Let the environment guide your choices.

PALETTE COMBINATIONS THAT WORK

- + **Cream and dusty blue.**
Her: cream or ivory flowy dress. Him: dusty blue or chambray button-down, tan or oatmeal chinos. One of the most photographically beautiful combinations in natural Austin light.
- + **Sage and warm white.**
Her: sage dress or set. Him: white or off-white linen shirt, dark chinos or jeans. Earthy, organic, and stunning outdoors — especially against Austin's greenery and limestone.
- + **Terracotta and camel.**
Her: terracotta or rust-toned dress. Him: camel or tan shirt, dark jeans. Warm and rich. Photographs beautifully in fall sessions and golden hour light.
- + **Warm neutrals throughout.**
Both in cream, tan, camel, and soft white with texture variations. Works beautifully when you want the focus entirely on your faces and your connection, not the clothes.
- + **Deep jewel tones.**
Burgundy, deep emerald, sapphire blue. Rich and dramatic for fall or evening sessions. One of you anchors in the jewel tone while the other complements with a neutral.

When in doubt: send us photos before you buy. We'll give you honest feedback on what will work on camera at your chosen location. A five-minute check saves you from bringing something that won't photograph the way you hope.

04

Hair & Makeup.

The goal isn't to look different. It's to look like the best, most polished version of yourselves — in a way that still feels completely natural ten years from now.

HER — MAKEUP & HAIR

- + **Go slightly heavier than your everyday look.**
Camera lenses flatten features. What feels like too much in the mirror reads balanced through a lens. Matte or satin finish throughout — dewy foundations create uneven shine outdoors and with flash.
- + **SPF flashback is real. Avoid physical sunscreens.**
Zinc oxide and titanium dioxide create a white cast in photographs. Use SPF-free foundation or chemical SPF. We photograph with natural light and flash — both can trigger flashback.
- + **Hair should move, not hold.**
Whatever style you choose, make sure it moves. Stiff, heavily sprayed hair looks flat on camera. Day-old hair holds better and sits more naturally than freshly washed.
- + **Bring touch-up essentials.**
Lip liner, lipstick, blotting papers, setting powder, a small brush. Texas heat and outdoor sessions mean touch-ups between looks. Prepared means 30 seconds, not a production.

HIM — GROOMING TIPS

- + **Haircut: 3-5 days before. Not the morning of.**
A fresh cut that's had a few days to settle looks natural and polished. A same-day cut can look too sharp or uneven on camera.
- + **Shave or trim the night before.**
Clean-shaven: shave the evening before to avoid razor redness. Beard: shape and trim 1-2 days ahead so it looks intentional, not rushed.
- + **Moisturize. Starting now.**
Skin condition shows clearly in photos. Moisturize daily for a few days before. Well-hydrated skin photographs with natural texture rather than rough or flaky.
- + **Mattifying powder is your friend.**
Translucent setting powder reduces shine without looking made up. Texas heat creates shine fast. Pick some up at any drugstore. Highly recommended for outdoor sessions.

AUSTIN HEAT — PLAN FOR IT

Blotting papers, setting spray, and mattifying powder are non-negotiable for outdoor Austin sessions. Bring them both.

05

Austin Timing & Locations.

Timing is everything in Austin. The light, the heat, and the season all shape what's possible. Here's what to know before we plan your session.

WHEN TO SHOOT

+ **Golden hour is the ideal window.**

One hour before sunset gives you warm, directional light that flatters every skin tone and every outfit. In summer, that's 7:30-8:30 PM. In fall and winter, 5:30-6:30 PM. We plan around this by default.

+ **Morning is the second-best option.**

The first 90 minutes after sunrise offers soft, even light without the heat. Ideal for couples who prefer cooler temperatures and a quieter Austin.

+ **Avoid harsh midday sun in summer.**

11 AM to 4 PM in Austin summer creates harsh shadows, squinting, and sweat. If your schedule requires midday, we find shade and work with it — but golden hour is always worth waiting for.

+ **Fall is the best season.**

September through November: bearable heat, extraordinary light, rich natural color. The most popular season for engagement sessions in Austin for a reason. Book early.

LOCATION TYPES IN AUSTIN

+ **Natural outdoor locations.**

Barton Creek Greenbelt, Blunn Creek, Brushy Creek, Barton Springs. Lush greenery, water, and limestone. Earthy tones and flowy fabrics work beautifully. Austin at its most iconic.

+ **Urban and architectural.**

East Austin murals, South Congress, downtown. Structured, editorial, bold. Works beautifully with more polished looks. Great for couples who are more city than countryside.

+ **The Domain.**

Upscale, walkable, and beautifully lit. Clean architecture, landscaped pathways, and a polished urban feel. Great for couples who want something refined without going fully downtown.

+ **Historic and romantic.**

The Commodore Perry Estate grounds, Texas Old Town, Laguna Gloria. Elegant, timeless, distinctly Austin. Pairs beautifully with elevated, formal looks.

+ **Mixed sessions.**

Two locations in one session — urban and natural, or two different environments. We plan the flow so outfit changes happen naturally between locations.

Not sure which location fits your style? Tell us a little about yourselves and we'll recommend the right setting. We know these locations in every season and every light. That's part of what you're hiring us for.

06

How to Prepare.

The more decisions you make before the session, the more present you can be when it matters. Here's exactly what to do, organized by when to do it.

ONE WEEK BEFORE

- + Finalize both outfits and try everything on together
- + Send us photos of each look if you want feedback
- + Book hair and makeup appointments if using a professional
- + Schedule haircut 3-5 days before session (him)
- + Confirm session time, location, and parking
- + Think about meaningful props you might want to bring
- + Start moisturizing daily (both of you)

THREE DAYS BEFORE

- + Steam or press all outfits and hang them
- + Do a hair and makeup trial if trying something new
- + Avoid salty foods that cause puffiness
- + Start hydrating more than usual
- + Clean the engagement ring for close-up shots
- + Trim or shape beard if keeping it (him)
- + Get on a reasonable sleep schedule

THE DAY BEFORE

- + Pack your bag: outfits, shoes, all accessories
- + Touch-up kit: blotting papers, setting powder, lips
- + Shave (him) or style hair for settling overnight
- + Confirm all session details one more time
- + Lay out everything — make zero morning decisions
- + Do something relaxing together. Rest well.

MORNING OF

- + Eat a real meal — not a granola bar. Both of you.
- + Apply makeup in natural light if possible
- + Give yourselves extra time to get ready
- + Arrive 5-10 minutes early
- + Leave the stress in the car
- + Show up excited — everything else is handled.

"The couples who walk away with images they love showed up knowing what they wanted, prepared enough to feel confident, and present enough to let the moments happen."

07

What to Expect.

Knowing how the session flows removes all the guesswork. Here's exactly what happens from the moment you arrive through the day you receive your gallery.

WHEN YOU ARRIVE

We ease in. There's no jumping straight into formal poses — the first 10-15 minutes are always a warmup. Getting comfortable in the space, finding the light, laughing at something. By the time the real work begins, you've already forgotten to be nervous.

HOW WE GUIDE YOU

We direct everything — where to stand, how to angle your bodies, where to look, what to do with your hands. You will never be left standing there wondering what to do next. If something feels uncomfortable or off, just say so. We'd rather find what works for you than have you hold anything that doesn't feel right.

THE MIDDLE OF THE SESSION

This is where the best images almost always happen. You're warmed up, relaxed, and no longer thinking about the camera. The session stops feeling like a session. We're still working — but it doesn't feel like it anymore. The most genuine expressions, the most natural connection — they come from this part.

OUTFIT CHANGES

Outfit changes are planned into the session timeline. We'll find a comfortable, private spot and plan the flow so each change feels like a reset. Touch up your lips, reset your hair, take a breath. Each look gets its own energy.

AFTER YOUR SESSION

You'll receive a link to your private, password-protected gallery of fully edited, high-resolution images. We edit for color, light, and overall mood — every image consistent and polished, ready to print, frame, post, and use for your save-the-dates. Questions about sizes, products, or usage? Just reply.

"We don't just show up and start shooting. We arrive having thought about you, your story, your location, and your light. Every detail is considered before we ever press the shutter."

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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